

# Shrews and moles

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|----------|--------------|
| PHYLUM   | Chordata     |
| CLASS    | Mammalia     |
| ORDER    | Soricomorpha |
| FAMILIES | 4            |
| SPECIES  | 428          |

**Shrews, moles, and solenodons** are voracious predators of invertebrates and other small vertebrates. They live frantic lives fueled by a very high metabolic rate; at least a few have toxic saliva for disabling prey. They have small eyes and small (or absent) external ears, often hidden in short,

dense fur. Some aquatic forms have webbed or hairy-fringed swimming feet. Moles have broad forefeet and strong claws for burrowing, as well as a long, flexible snout for detecting prey. Shrews are a species-rich family found throughout much of the world except Australasia. Moles are largely confined to the northern hemisphere, and solenodons are exclusively West Indian.

## COMPETENT CLIMBER

Shrews have small eyes and well-developed snouts. Despite poor vision, this Eurasian shrew is an adept climber. It also has acute hearing, even though there is no external ear flap.



## *Solenodon paradoxus*

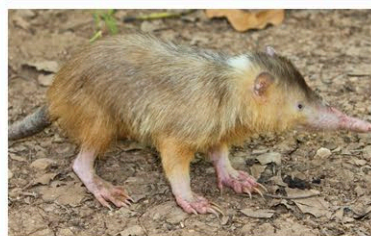
### Hispaniolan solenodon



**Location** Caribbean (Hispaniola)

**Length** 11–12½ in (28–32 cm)  
**Tail** 6½–10 in (17–26 cm)  
**Weight** 2¼ lb (1 kg)

**Social unit** Individual  
**Status** Endangered



The 2 species of solenodon—Cuban and Hispaniolan—are large, long-tailed, shrewlike, nocturnal insectivores. Both are under threat. The snout of the Hispaniolan solenodon is long and mobile. Its fur varies from black to red-brown, and its feet, tail, and upper ears are almost hairless. It is fast and agile. It noses and scrabbles on the forest floor with its sharp claws for insects, worms, small lizards, fruit, and other plant matter. Its venomous bite is used for defense and to stun prey.

## *Sorex araneus*

### Eurasian shrew



**Location** Europe to N. Asia

**Length** 2–3¼ in (5–8 cm)  
**Tail** 1–1¼ in (2.5–4.5 cm)  
**Weight** ¾–1½ oz (5–14 g)

**Social unit** Individual  
**Status** Least concern



One of the smallest mammals, the Eurasian shrew is adaptable, aggressive, and voracious. It must eat 80–90 percent of its body weight every 24 hours, and it hunts in up to 10 bursts of activity, according to season and conditions. Food includes insects, worms, and carrion. Adults are solitary except for a brief courtship in spring or early fall. After a gestation period of 24–25 days, 6–7 young are born in a special breeding nest made from woven grass and dry leaves. Larger than the usual resting nest, this is similarly sited under a log, root, rock, or in an old burrow. The Eurasian shrew has a pointed, flexible snout and short legs. Its fur is dark brown to black on the back, paler brown on the flanks, and gray-white on the underside. It is territorial, making ultrasonic squeaks, especially when a female gathers her offspring. If cornered, this shrew readily bites.

## *Megasorex gigas*

### Giant Mexican shrew



**Location** S.W. Mexico

**Length** 3¼–3½ in (8–9 cm)  
**Tail** 1½–2 in (4–5 cm)  
**Weight** ¾–7½ oz (10–12 g)

**Social unit** Individual  
**Status** Least concern



The sole species in the genus *Megasorex*, this large, compact-bodied, but short-tailed shrew prods with its prominent, pointed snout among leaves and loose soil for worms, grubs, millipedes, spiders, and other small prey. The upperparts are dark brown or grayish brown, becoming paler on the underside. This shrew prefers areas of damp soil and moist undergrowth in grassland and forest, ranging from the lowlands to altitudes of 5,600 ft (1,700 m). Only some 20 giant Mexican shrews have been studied and their nesting and breeding habits are not yet known.

## *Neomys fodiens*

### Eurasian water shrew



**Location** Europe to N. Asia

**Length** 2½–3¼ in (6.5–9.5 cm)  
**Tail** 1¼–3¼ in (4.5–8 cm)  
**Weight** ¾–7½ oz (8–25 g)

**Social unit** Individual  
**Status** Least concern



This shrew hunts aquatic insects, small fish, and frogs. It also feeds on land, on worms, beetles, and grubs, and so can survive in damp woods. The small eyes and ears, and the long, pointed snout are typically shrewlike. Solitary but less aggressive than other shrews, the Eurasian water shrew establishes a series of runways and burrows and has a nest of dry grass and old leaves. Here, after 14–21 days' gestation, the female suckles her litter of 4–7 young for approximately 6 weeks.

## *Suncus etruscus*

### Etruscan shrew



**Location** S. Europe, S. to S.E. Asia, Sri Lanka, N. to E. Africa, W. Africa

**Length** 1½–2 in (4–5 cm)  
**Tail** ¾–1¼ in (2–3 cm)  
**Weight** ¼–½ oz (2–3 g)

**Social unit** Individual  
**Status** Least concern



Also called the pygmy white-toothed shrew or Savi's shrew, this species actively hunts for small prey such as insects, worms, snails, and spiders, then rests for a few hours, through day and night. It nests in a small hole or crevice and is solitary most of the year, forming pairs only in the breeding season. The gestation period is 27–28 days and litter size 2–5, with up to 6 litters per year.



## *Blarina brevicauda*

### Northern short-tailed shrew



**Location** S. Canada to N. and E. USA

**Length** 4¾–5½ in (12–14 cm)  
**Tail** 1¼ in (3 cm)  
**Weight** 1½ oz (20 g)

**Social unit** Variable  
**Status** Least concern



uses mainly scent and touch to hunt its main prey of soil-living animals and—unusually for the shrew group—smaller mammals such as voles and mice, and even some plant matter. This shrew rests and feeds largely underground in runways and old mole or vole tunnels, usually 4–20 in (10–50 cm) deep, and stores items in cold weather. The eyes and ears are tiny, and the snout stouter and less pointed than in other shrews.

ears concealed by fur  
 grayish black fur



Like most shrews, this large, robust species has poor sight but excellent sense of smell, and its venomous bite (due to toxic saliva) helps disable prey. It